

The Buddha as Exemplar and Archetype

Bhante Bodhidhamma · Dharma Talks · 50:27

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā-sambuddhassa

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Homage to the blessed, noble and fully self-enlightened ones.

So this is just trying to look at the Buddha's life from the point of view as an exemplar. And I've chopped it up into 12 different things so that you can see the sort of passage that he went through, his own particular journey. I hate that cliché, but I'll have to use it for the time being.

So it's said that way in the distant mists of time when he was born in a particular era of a particular Buddha called Dīpaṅkara, that he met this Buddha and put a cloak down to stop him stepping into a puddle. And he was so amazed by this Buddha that he made there and then a determination to become self-enlightened, a fully self-enlightened Buddha just like this man Dīpaṅkara. Now it's not - I don't think it's of any use to try and discuss whether in fact Dīpaṅkara ever existed or not, because remember Eastern mythology is very circular, and the way that you substantiate a leader is by saying that it's all happened before. So all these eastern traditions have leaders which have come before - the Niganthas is number so and so in a whole line of Niganthas which produced the Jain tradition.

But for us what's important is this act of resolution, an act of resolution to really make the process of purification, the process of enlightenment, the full aim of our lives. And that total determination, you see. Total determination. And in his case, self-enlightened. But although we have this teaching, that doesn't mean to say that we don't become self-enlightened, because ultimately it's we that have to do the work. All we can say is that the distinction between us and the Buddha was that he gave us some clues as to which way to go. But the fact is that the whole process is completely internally dependent on us.

So that's the first thing that you can contemplate is the importance of making that decision, of making a resolution in your own time and your own way. Now, just to make it once in a lifetime isn't enough, you see, because it has to be constantly reinforced, constantly reinforced. If you think of any other situation in people's lives, for instance, just a partnership or a marriage, they might go through a small ceremony and they think that's it. And of course, seven, fifteen years down the line, they're walking away from each other. And the problem has been is that they haven't recommitted themselves, recommitted themselves and gone through the pain of a relationship. Other people are hell, remember.

So it's a case of understanding that this resolution, this complete commitment of the heart to the path, you

see, is the kernel position you have to take, that resolution. So that's the first thing to contemplate.

The second one, of course, is that after he made this great resolution, he was then born, it is said, for countless lifetimes trying to get it right, trying to get the perfections right, trying to purify his heart. Now again, from our point of view, it's not necessary to believe that he lived thousands of lifetimes, but the myth is telling us that this path is very long, very gradual, and very difficult.

Now, I don't want to depress you, but that's what it's telling us, that it's okay to make this decision, but actually, we've entered into a path which is going to demand everything from us, everything, eventually. In the spiritual life, remember, you don't get anything back until you've given up something. And you never know what you're going to get. It's not like you've got an old car which is broken down and you think, well, I'll get rid of it, I'll go and get a new one. And you know which one you're going to get when you drop yours. In the spiritual life, you don't really know at all what you're going to get until you make that leap of faith and give something up.

So that's the next thing, is to really consider that. And the Buddha, of course, reinforces that in his own teachings. He's constantly telling people this is gradual. It's gradual. There's no sudden enlightenment. Now, I know there are certain schools of Buddhism that talk about the sudden enlightenment, but it's not sudden in that sense at all. If you talk to, for instance, Zen monks about their sudden enlightenment, you find they've been meditating for 25 years before this sudden enlightenment came from them. So it's not nothing - in other words, you don't get anything for nothing. You have to go through the training.

And this training is twofold - it's both the purification of the heart and the growth of the heart. Heart here meaning our whole disposition, our whole disposition. So as you know, as soon as you sit, you can see these hindrances, you can see these impurities arising. And they're there just within deep conditioning within us. Even if you only believe in appearing in this world just this once with birth, you know, we've picked up all this stuff, all this conditioning. And as soon as you come to sit, then of course the stuff begins to arise. And the whole process of meditation is the purification of that part of us.

But the other side, remember, is the growth of all these perfections. One of them, of course, is resolution, the determination to do what you say you're going to do. And that's one of the things that you can impress upon yourself just these three days. Once you've set yourself the rhythm of the retreat that you want, then you maintain it. That's your discipline, that's your courage, and that's your resolution, you see. If you fail, of course, you haven't got to get into beating yourself up and saying you're useless and all that. Sometimes you have to have an act of humility to recognize that you've reached too far. So it's always good to make sure that you're not pushing yourself too much, but on the other hand, you are pushing yourself a bit. As one of my early teachers, Roshi Kennett, used to say, that you have to push yourself gently. Some of you know, I think, Roshi Kennett, or used to know her. She started Throssel Hole.

So that's the next thing, is to recognize that the path is one of effort, and it takes that commitment, and that it's one of purification. You have to work at it. You have to really work at it.

So finally, the Buddha's ready for the big thing. He's ready for the full self-enlightenment show. And he's waiting in the Tusita heaven. Just waiting for the opportunity to arise. And there it comes, you see. North India, born to a prince, a local governor. In actuality, he was what you might call a local lord who was under the local king of Kosala. But, you know, as it comes to the scriptures, he's this big king in North India. I suppose we would call him that, upper middle class king manager.

And he decides - there's a decision there to be born. And here's your classic Freudian trauma - his mother dies. Mother dies probably because of his birth, and that's somewhere in his heart, isn't it? And he loses his mother and he's passed on - I think it's a week after he's born he's passed on to his mother's sister. And he must have felt that. So already, you might say, this little child has not only gone through the pangs of rebirth, but the pangs of losing his mother. So already, as it were, he's come into life with real suffering already in that heart. The touch of suffering is already there. I might be a bit too Freudian there, but you understand what I'm saying.

And he's obviously precocious. Now that shouldn't amaze us. I mean if you think of somebody like Mozart - I think he wrote his first symphony when he was three or something. So when you realise that there are little beings who arise who are absolutely unbelievable, it was obvious that this little boy was something special. And the tale always goes, and you get it in other myths, that of course they meet the wise man. And the wise man recognizes that here is an extraordinary human being and what he says about this little human being is that either he'll become a world conqueror, a total world conqueror, or a fully self-enlightened person.

Now, that's the same for us. Now, it's not that we're all going to become world conquerors, but the choice is there. Is our lives going to be devoted to being great in the world or to being great spiritually? And that isn't just a decision we make at the beginning of our lives or somewhere. It's constant. Every time we say to ourselves, well, I'm going to have this cup of tea because I want to really enjoy it, we've chosen the world. If you have a cup of tea in order to investigate the process and with the intention to feed the body, not feed our emotional life with it, then we've chosen the spiritual path. So that division is with us all the time. That's not a problem. And in this particular story, it's put at this very heightened level. You see, here we have a little being who could have conquered the whole world or he could have become self-enlightened.

So that's the next thing to contemplate, this idea that all the time the choice is there before us, that choice between choosing the world or choosing spiritual life, choosing our enlightenment.

So, of course, when his father heard this, he was in a state of horror, you see, because this was, at that time, his only son. And as far as I know, it remained his only son. I think I'm correct, yeah. So, obviously, he wanted his only son to be heir. So then we have this part of the myth that tells us that his father went to this great extent to make sure that his son never suffered, make sure he had all the food he wanted and as he grew older all the sex, drugs, and rock and roll. And as he approaches and he gets through teenage and

what not then he comes to a point of going through all that loveliness of getting married and all that but there must be something, should we say, disturbing him at that point, you see. And it comes again through a particular myth.

Before we go into that, do remember that the whole of our society is drawn, is manufactured, the whole of our economic, political life is there to draw us into the world. The whole of capitalism, everything that we have, is to make us emboldened in the world, is to make us see our life in the world. So he's born into the world and the world wants him. But again, there's this little pain.

And it comes out in the story of his meeting with the *devadūta*, the messengers from the gods. That's how it's put. So he's out there hunting and doing his thing, killing beasts and all that. And he comes across, in sequence, somebody who's very sick on the road - there if you've been to India you know exactly what that means - somebody who's very old and crooked and really old, a corpse, and finally this ascetic sitting under a tree.

Each time he asks, you know, what is this? Because he's been shielded from this. This is what the myth tells us. He hasn't actually looked at this stuff. And after they've described it to him, there's the kernel question, you see. Does this happen to me? So here's a young man, full of energy, full of all that virility and all that, and he suddenly sees sickness, old age, and death. And of course there's this ascetic sitting under a tree which in the story symbolises hope, the escape from sickness, old age, and death.

But for him it's obviously become a psychological crisis. I think what we would call today an identity crisis. He's into a proper identity crisis, an existential identity crisis. And when does it hit him? You see, it hits him somewhere in his middle twenties. Now if you think of your lives - I don't know about you, how old are you Gabriel? It's coming.

So if you think of your life and you look back into your middle twenties, you'll see that there's a change of mentality because there's a sudden realisation that youth is over. And that's when people get serious. They get married, they take their job seriously, some even take out pensions. And it all happens in that period as you move towards the first ugly inklings of middle age.

So there he is, you see, at that point. And he decides that he's got to go and really work this out. He's in a psychological crisis. He needs to work it out. And the only way he can think of doing it is to join the ascetics because they are the only people at that time who are offering anything beyond the worldly life. He probably spent hours talking to the Brahmins, talking about their philosophy and understandings, because later on, of course, he knows it deeply. He knows all the arguments, and he must have picked it up during that youthful time. He studied the Vedas. So he's abandoned that scholastic thing. He wants to abandon the good life.

And there are two things. Well, the other thing that makes him abandon life is that they've obviously had a big party. And in the morning when he wakes up, he's got all these bodies around him. And there's puke

and saliva. It's all horrible. And he sees the other side of pleasure, which is, of course, the hangover. And he sees that pleasure is not going to bring that happiness, it's not going to bring an end to the suffering that he feels, this existential suffering of sickness, old age, and ultimately death.

So it hits hard, doesn't it? Those of you who've had a scrape with death know what he might have been going through. Those of you who've had people who've died around you know that it can hit you hard, you see. In fact, the Buddha says there are four types of people. Those who wake up, in other words, who really see that their life has to have the spiritual dimension, upon the hearing of death - just the word will wake them up. Some don't wake up until they realise that somebody has died, comes on the TV or something. Some people don't wake up until somebody very close to them dies, and some unfortunates don't wake up until, of course, it's their turn to die. So you don't want to leave it that late.

So there he is, and two things have shaken him, right? Sickness, old age, and death, and the vanity, the emptiness of pleasure, of worldly pleasure, the emptiness of it. Even sex, for instance, which might bring a lot of pleasure, is ultimately empty. Or just sex, shall we say. And I always remember Woody Allen saying that the experience of sex is an empty experience, but as empty experiences go...

So, it's that realisation. And for us, you see, we wouldn't be here now, actually. We wouldn't at all be in this room, any of us, if we hadn't had some inkling around those areas. But, again, it's not something that becomes a huge crisis for everybody. It's something that can be very gradual, a gradual pulling away because of the little bits of suffering that come from it, little bits of realisation. And of course, our own bodies are our own teachers. That's why I said this morning at the meal time, we're so dependent on the body for our teaching, because it's the body which gets ill, it's the body which grows old, and it's the body which dies. And it's when we realise that we are embodied, we are actually in this body, this body is the way we know the world, it's the way we experience the world, that we suddenly realise, or we begin to realise, that in fact we take care of it, not smash it around too much.

So those are contemplations, those are daily, hourly, moment to moment contemplations. As it arises one contemplates that, one reflects upon these things. And what it's urging us to do is to abandon, is to let go, is not to attach to these things.

Remember, when we talk about abandonment, letting go, it's not a destruction. We're not talking about not eating. We talk about eating in a particular way. So take, for instance, sleep. We're not talking about abandoning sleep, because it's a lovely time and we all want to spend some time in oblivion every day. It's recognizing that sleep has a purpose, it's there to rest the body. But if we seek happiness in oblivion, then of course the bed constantly beckons us. Every time we feel a bit tired, we launch ourselves onto the bed, you see.

As you go to bed, you look upon it as a stinking pit, so you don't see it as a place where you're going to get pleasure. It's just there to rest the body, just like food is there to nourish the body. These are contemplations to be taken up.

So he's now on the point of leaving. So here's what's known as the Great Renunciation. And it's not as though people haven't done this before. Both men and women have had to leave everything to go to war, for instance. People are often drawn out of their style of life for one reason or another. Some people are shaken and they leave everything. Some people are kicked out anyway. People are made redundant and stuff. Some are born to leave, some have to leave and whatever.

So there comes this point where he abandons, he renounces the worldly life. And it's put in the story that he even saw the birth of his son. So there's that huge attachment to this little child. And yet even so, he gets on his favourite horse, his special horse Kantaka, with his servant Channa, and off he goes.

These days that can be harshly judged as his abandoning his family and all that. But you must remember in those days they're very extended families, and I can't imagine that he did it without long consultation and argument and all that sort of stuff and cajoling. And then finally, I'm sure he said to them, as I said to my mother, I'm only doing it for three years. When I said that, she disappeared with this cloud of absolute... I said to her I'm going to join the order and she just collapsed into this awful weeping, and I put my arm around and said, "Mum," I said, "I'm only going for three years," and she stopped. It was just because she saw it as an abandonment.

So one presumes that he did have the goodwill of the family behind him. And there comes this point where he reaches a river. So here it is, you see, crossing the Rubicon. There's a point where we make that crossing, where we've built up the faith, we've built up the understanding, and finally we make that leap of faith.

Now, in terms of the Buddha, okay, it was a big dramatic moment. It's part of the myth. But for us, it's every day. Every day you have to make that leap of faith. Every day you've got to cross that Rubicon. And it's crossing from what? It's crossing from the worldly life to the spiritual life.

And he cuts off all his hair, which was the idea of those days, throws all his rich clothes away, dons rag robes, and even leaves his horse Kantaka, who dies out of grief. It was terrible. But Channa can't leave him. I think he follows him in the end. He follows him, doesn't he, Channa? Eventually. Later on.

So there we have it. Finally, you might say, he's cut from the worldly life. So that's another point of contemplation for us. In our own lives, the idea that we have to really make that commitment some way.

And that's the whole point really of taking, in the Buddhist tradition, taking refuges and precepts, of actually joining a specific tradition within Buddhism. It's in all religions. And that's why it's always ceremonious. That's why it's always done in community. It's just like a marriage ceremony. People I know who've been in partnership for a long time. I mean, I did a little marriage ceremony for a very old friend of mine. Partnership for 15 years. But then a marriage ceremony was something else. It deepens the commitment to the person. It's a funny thing, but anybody who's been in a long relationship who goes to a marriage ceremony, and I'm not talking about a religious thing, it's a communal declaration. Much the

way, say, the Quakers do it. And it has an effect. It has an effect of deepening that commitment to the other person as person, as an individual.

So you'll find that in all traditions there is that ceremony of commitment by the person. And when I myself became a Buddhist, I did it up at Throstle Nest Hall, and it's five days. So it's not just a matter of saying a few words. It was a five-day long... There were five different ceremonies. And it was all about this business of renouncing, of burning one's karma. I can't remember the full gist of it now, but by the end of it, you definitely felt you'd joined something. And there was that feeling of settlement. There was that feeling of coming home.

That's one of the big feelings in the spiritual life, that finally you've found your tradition, you've found your teacher. And it might, I mean, as you know, I didn't stay in the same tradition, I started with Zen. It's not as though it's blocked in time, that you can't move, but there's that feeling of grounding yourself finally in a spiritual practice. So that's this crossing of the Rubicon, that's this crossing of the river, and letting go.

So then he joins the great meditation traditions of the time and he goes through two teachers, and what these teachers teach him is how to establish ecstasy within himself. And that means that you don't actually need the world. Just through the practices of *samatha* meditation, concentration meditation, the practices of mantra, the practices of what we call looking at *kasiṇas*, images, which you then internalise, one begins to recognise that you can actually attain enormous ecstasy within your own heart without any help from the outside world at all.

So you don't need sex, drugs, rock and roll, you don't need cinema, you don't need anything. You can actually sit there and develop this enormous state within yourself because that's the capability of the mind and heart within itself. And once you've established it on an object and you've internalised it, you don't even need that object. So one of the main places is using the breath. So you just need the body as it were. So all you need is, in India anyway, all you need is a bit of shelter, a tree, a bit of clothes, somebody to give you a bit of rice every day, and you sit in ecstasy. And that's it. So you can imagine why it was attractive. This is one of the attractions of the monastic life for those who can practise it. It's not within everybody's gift.

So what does that teach us? That teaches us that there is another way of actually producing happiness. But every time he came out of these states, he found himself back in dear old Gautama, back in dear old Siddhartha, just lumped with all this suffering. It wasn't an answer to sickness, old age and death. It wasn't an answer to his existential crisis. It was just another way of displacing his life into a cloud of beauty. A pink cloud. It was lovely when he was there, but when he came out, it was pretty awful.

And of course you can get addicted to that like any drug. So as soon as he began to realise this, of course he recognised that that wasn't the path. And each time it is said he was so brilliant at his meditation that the teacher would ask him to be a teacher with him. And each time he said, well, I can't, I don't, I'm not

fully satisfied. There must be something else.

So that's the first thing, that when in your meditation beautiful states arise, fine, we're not trying to get rid of them, we're not trying to destroy beauty or happiness, but that's not the end of the path, that's not what it's about. So it arises, fantastic, and then you notice it passing away. And when you see yourself grasping for it as it's passing away, when you come back to the meditation hall with the intention of re-establishing that state, then know that you've fallen into a relationship of attachment, which could cause suffering, which could cause dissatisfaction.

So then abandoning that, he then went into self-mortification. Now the psychology of self-mortification rests on the idea that all suffering is bodily based. Now if you think about that, most of it is. Where do you experience suffering if it's not in the body? The hunger, wanting to eat, wanting to see something. Just the physical pain of the body. So self-mortification or those exercises, especially the one that he chose, which was to starve oneself, really reduces the body to, shall we say, almost a skeletal state where, as it were, suffering is lessened in the body.

Now, for those of you, if you've done a 10-day fast... anybody done a 10-day fast? Right. So I don't know whether you experienced it, but normally the first three days are horrible because there's this huge, all these horrible things are pouring out of the body. But then you keep drinking water and then there suddenly comes this place where it's absolutely beautiful. And it remains like that. It's just absolutely beautiful. The body doesn't feel hungry. Of course, it's eating itself, but it doesn't feel hungry. And your passions are down. You don't feel passionate about anything. Everything is lovely subdued, beautifully subdued. And, of course, you can go on like that until you get close to death, and I think it begins to hurt.

So the idea is just to eat enough just to keep that idea of the body of not exciting the body because it's all based, excitement has its base in the senses. So all that happened there of course was that he obviously reached these points of suffering and there came this point where we could say he despaired.

Now, that will come to us, the sense of despair about our practice. And it comes to us because of expectation. It comes to us because we think we should be somewhere else than where we are. So there will come these little moments in our spiritual life where we think, nothing's happening, I'm not getting anywhere, and all this sort of stuff. And they're little jabs of despair. So you have to be careful of those.

He himself abandoned that self-mortification business and with it his five disciples left him because he said he'd gone soft. So anyway he wanders off by himself and he's sitting on the roadside and a woman comes along with a bowl of rice pudding, which is a very sacred food in Buddhism. So she comes along with this bowl of rice pudding and she sees this monk by the roadside and the myth tells us that she thought that it was a god and she offered this food to a god. But I think we can realistically say that what she saw was somebody who was on death's door and looking pretty sad, and she probably was carrying it to some sort of family as a gift and when she had a little chat with him she said, look, you better have this rice pudding.

So he eats this rice pudding and of course it lifts, it lifts his body, it lifts his spirits, and he can't let go of the idea that there must be an end to suffering. It's there within him, the kernel of the idea is within him. And he must have been reviewing his life and he must have been reviewing everything he's been through and perhaps he's wandered over the three years that he promised his family and he's thinking he might go back, and as he's reviewing he remembers this point in childhood.

And he must have been about six, seven, maybe eight, and he's watching his father during the ploughing ceremony, just watching his father. And for some reason, he remembers the quality of that watching, something which obviously he hadn't been aware of, either through the *jhānic* meditations, the absorption meditations, or through all these practices which are to do with self-mortification.

And if you think about it, that's quite reasonable because all those practices are about gaining something, about getting something. You're doing something for something else. I'm doing the *jhāna* in order to get over sickness, old age and death. I'm self-mortificating in order to get over. So it's always drawing that person out of the present moment.

But here he remembers this point where he's watching his father and he's just in the present moment. Now, if you think of children, especially around the age of three, four, two, three, four, you see it comes naturally. They see a bug and you see they just absorb into it. Now they don't have the language to think about it. And they just absorb into it just out of a total interest. They're completely there.

And one of the signs that a child is in that state, and we ourselves in that state, is the jaw drops. And you get parents like my old man used to tell me to shut my mouth. "Shut your mouth, son." You see kids, don't you see? And what it is is that when there's no jaw, when there's no tongue, there's no thought. If you're in your meditation you might catch that when a thought comes, there's a vibration on the tongue because it's just so intimately connected.

So it's just like a child, just absorbed into that. And then you see, after the absorption, after that business of taking in the image, then there's a stop and the child turns around and says, "What is it?" So mum says, "It's a slug." So from that point on, there's a title, there's a name, it's a slug. So that child will never look at a slug again. What they will see is the image that they had of a slug imposed upon the slug that they now see. And that's the whole distortion that conceptual thinking does for us.

To get back through all that language and all that conception, back to the original mind, back to that original way of seeing things, is the process of enlightenment. Because once we're back there we're back to that amazing intelligence that we have which is now informed. That's the paradox: it's been informed through language. We couldn't have got here without language. We couldn't have got here without the teaching. But now the intelligence is informed, it clarifies itself of all those conceptual thinking and it sees anew.

So here's the Buddha. He remembers that moment and he's so inspired by it. And also remember he's

despaired. He knows now this is it because he doesn't see anything else. He's been through all the traditions. He's done everything. The world can't offer him anything else. So he approaches the tree which we now call the Bodhi tree, and interestingly enough the leaves are shaped like a heart, are they not? And he sits under this big leafy Bodhi tree by the side of the river and he makes this great determination.

So we've had the great renunciation, so now we have the great determination. And the determination is, "Right I've done everything, this is it. I'm going to sit here and crack this problem or I will die." Or I will die. That's the commitment.

And it was interesting because when one of my teachers came to the Bihar in Birmingham and I'd been, I was already ordained for about four or five years or something. And he came along and I'd been practising a little bit in India, I remember, but I was living at the Bihar anyway. And I'd been to Burma before and I'd got very ill with amoebic dysentery and amoebic hepatitis and all sorts of things. And he wanted me to join him, and he sent one of the monks to tell me. He said, "Anita wants you to come and join him."

So I said, "Well, frankly," I said, "the last time I was in Burma, I nearly died. I said, I don't particularly have a, I really don't want to go east again." So he went back, and he came back with a message. "If you're not prepared to die, forget it." So obviously he was mirroring back to me the memory of the Buddha.

So there's the Buddha. He's now made this great determination. So for us, it's little bits, making that determination. So every time you sit, one of the big mistakes we make is because it's become habitual, we just take a seat. We just sit here. And of course, nothing much happens.

The mind wanders, we just get caught up in it, and we might feel a bit more relaxed. So every time you sit, you have to re-establish that commitment. And that's your determination. It's not a great determination, we don't have to worry too much about death. It's a great determination here, now. The great determination to commit ourselves 101% to this moment of meditation. And that's when you get the fruit. That's when you get the fruits of your practice.

As the story goes, of course, he did become enlightened. It took him six hours. There's your standard. If you can sit six hours, you'll probably make it. So he became enlightened at that point.

Now, he then spends the first night, the first three nights, trying to understand what he's seen. When we chant in the morning, I chant the Wheel of Dependent Origination. So that's the psychology, that's what he understood. It tells us about why we suffer, the psychology of suffering. And I do it three times in the thing to commemorate that moment, because he went forward on it, then he saw how it came back on itself, and then he did it again, forward and back, to make sure that he had fully understood the process. So that's what that chanting is about. It commemorates that moment. And that victory verse is what he was supposed to have told Ananda was what he spontaneously spoke when he became enlightened.

So now, having done that, having now made this moment of realization, realizing what the whole thing

was, what is the next thought? What is the next thought that comes to mind? Who can I teach? You see, with wisdom, compassion arises naturally. There was no break within that. It's not, ah, I've done it, fine, great, get back into bed. It was like it didn't end there. There was this immediate movement out of the heart. Who can I teach?

And of course, there's that little doubt. And again, it's put mythically as the great Brahma Sahampati comes down and says to him, look, there are some with only a little dust in their eyes. There are people who will understand this stuff. So it's with that reflection that when he looks at the world, he thinks, who is going to understand this stuff? And then when he reflects, well, what about my old teachers? And then he realizes they're dead, they've gone. So there's a sadness.

I saw this lovely statue in Burma the last time I was there. I'd never seen this before. And he sat in posture like this, but one hand is pointed to his heart like this. And I said to them, what's the meaning of that? I'd never seen that mudra. It's called a mudra posture. He says it's the sadness he felt when he realized his teachers had died.

So, having done that, he then thinks about this five disciples, remember, who've called him a scab and a deserter, and turned away from him and gone off. And he wanders off, and he walks, I think it's well over a hundred miles. So it's not as though he goes next door and says, hey, listen, I'm enlightened now, so I'll give you the message. He walks, he goes in search. The teacher goes out in search. Often it's put in the tradition that the pupil searches for the teacher, that when the teacher's ready, the pupil arises and the pupil's ready to teach and all that. Well, of course, we in our search have to search for our teacher. But the teacher also has to be ready, has to go out and search. Although I must say, the Indian tradition tends to be for somebody who feels they're ready to sit under a tree and just wait. And if somebody does come along, that's the test at it. They must be drawn into the teaching. But anyway, he makes this great effort to go out and teach. So that's our compassion.

So now you see, every one of us who've meditated, as soon as you say to somebody you've meditated, they expect you to be somehow different. They say, well, what's the effect? What's it done for you? And as soon as you open your mouth, you're teaching them. So if you go to people and say, well, I go to the Buddhist meditation, yeah, it's fantastic, and you're slowly getting drunk, then people are going to say, well, that's very interesting. So as soon as you take up a spiritual path, you take responsibility. And if you are, I mean again, don't get into big false guilt syndromes, but as soon as you don't behave according to a certain standard that the practice demands of you, then of course you're undermining the process of other people's spirituality because they become cynical. So you take on, whether you like it or not, you take on a certain responsibility.

So having taken on that responsibility, he searches for his disciples. And of course, he meets them. And as it's said, as soon as they saw him coming, they realized something had changed about him. They weren't going to make a seat for him or anything. But as soon as they saw him coming, they thought, well, no,

there's something strange. And that's when he gives the first talk about his teaching. And the whole teaching life begins after that. And he goes on, as you know, to establish an institution, to establish people around him, and eventually had enormous effect on human civilization.

But interestingly enough, that's not the full end of the story. Because in the scriptures, it says that *Mara*, the evil one, actually throws doubt and he attacks, Mara attacks with all his armies. And this actually happened just after the Enlightenment. And the question is, who are you to say that you are enlightened? Who are you to say that you've finished the path? How do you know that? So even when he made this huge realization, there was still the doubt, is this really the end of it? Is this really the end of suffering?

Now that doubt, it will always be with us. That doubt will always be with us and you have to be very careful not to get caught up in doubt. So it's not as though the Buddhist teaching is about believing what he said. We know that. It's not a belief system. It's a teaching. It's a practical teaching. We put it into practice and it makes sense. But the doubt, especially in ourselves, that often comes, everybody else can do it but not me. That's very careful when doubt comes up to make sure you don't get caught up in that thought and that you actually just stay with that position of not knowing. And that's very difficult for us because the self loves to be in control. It loves to know. We all want to know what we're going to do at the end of this course. We've all got it worked out what's going to happen when we leave this place. If you didn't, there'd be this anxiety. What am I going to do? So it's that case of really staying with that sense of doubt, it's an ugly feeling, and not to get caught up in it.

So he touched the earth as a witness to his enlightenment. So you'll often find that statue with his hand touching the earth. And basically, I suppose it's a call to people to say, well, you try and prove me wrong. Because in my understanding, in my experience, there is now no more suffering in me. I don't experience suffering at any level. That's not physical suffering for those of you. The body always has pain. It's the heart. There's no more of all this depression, anxiety, all the gamut of human misery. That's all gone.

But, interestingly enough, for seven years Mara hunts him. So it's an interesting thing in the scripture that we have this figure of Mara. Now you can either see it, of course, as some sort of devil, but you can see it as traces within the Buddha's mind, still there, little traces. So there's been this huge enlightenment, but there's still little traces. And Mara sends his three daughters. Lust, sensual pleasure, and boredom. So he obviously had a big problem with lust. If you compare that with Jesus Christ, interesting, because Christ seems to have been powered, doesn't he? Took him up to the mountain. So those are the three, those are your worldly pursuits: fame, friendship, riches, power, and of course seeking pleasure in the sensual world. So the Buddha obviously had had a good life, hadn't he? All that pleasure stuff. And his three daughters kept tempting him.

Now interestingly enough, why was boredom there? You see, because boredom is part of that pleasure syndrome. The more pleasure you have, the more it becomes obsolescent. You've always got to go for a bigger kick. And therefore, what moves you is the boredom of where you are. So boredom is the great

motivator towards addiction. So whenever you're bored, bored in your meditation, you never feed the boredom by distraction. You feed the boredom by, you undermine boredom by repetition. So when you're sitting there watching the breath and there's just this huge thing, this is so boring, so you feel the boredom, you know it's there, but you just keep watching the breath. And then eventually it fades away, because you're not feeding it. You know it's there. Remember, you've got to feel these things. You've got to actually experience them. You mustn't push them away.

So there comes a point, of course, when, and it's said seven years, which is one of these mythical cycles, isn't it? Seven years. His daughters haven't been successful. They go to Mara, their dad, and say, look... oh no, Mara sees that he hasn't been successful. He just can't get through to the Buddha to tempt him into all these things again. And so he says to his daughter, look, let's forget it. It's not working. And his daughter says, well, let's have just one more go, Dad. But eventually he slinks off. And what does the daughter say? Why are you going? Why is it that you are abandoning this quest? And Mara says, the Buddha sees me. And it's seeing, it's seeing what all the world has to offer as vanity, as emptiness, that undermines its power over us. So that by that time, it would seem that all, whatever was there by ancient conditioning was completely drained out over those seven years.

And then finally, what can we expect? What can we expect from this training? Well, there's this lovely tale in the scriptures where somebody says to the Buddha, look, this training you're going on about is bloody difficult. And he said, well, it is. It's hard. You've got to commit yourself and all that. And he said, okay, so what? He said, what do you get to *Nibbāna*? *Nibbāna* says, so what? What do you get when you get to *Nibbāna*? He says, when you achieve *Nibbāna*, you are happy and with it contented. And he's talking about himself. You are joyful and with it contented.

And when it comes to his own time to die, there's a lovely scripture where basically he just waits for the body to die. And he's just lying there on his side, and the people have come around him. Even at the end, he's ready to take somebody into the order, isn't he? Right at the end, right before he dies, he's ready to accept somebody in the order. And there he is, he's dying, and most of us are freaked out, eh? Most of us don't want anybody around. But here's this lovely peace and just this letting go of the body. Letting go of the body.

And of course, great sadness from that, from the younger monks. They all start crying, and the nuns and all that. And the elders say, what do you expect? Everything arises and passes away. And that was one of the Buddha's pet sayings. Everything arises and passes away. There's nothing in this world worth holding on to. Nothing in this world worth holding on to.

So, I hope that's been of some use to you in terms of how to reflect upon your own spiritual life. And that's it.